

# SWIM & WATER SAFETY

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Health & Physical Education · Year 7–8

Victorian Curriculum F–10 Version 2.0

STUDENT NAME

CLASS

TEACHER

VCHPEP125 · VCHPEP126 · VCHPEP129 · VCHPEP130 · VCHPEM146 · Safety (S) · LPA · FMS

Victoria has some of the most beautiful — and most dangerous — water environments in Australia. This workbook builds the knowledge, skills and confidence to keep yourself and others safe in and around water.

Complete all activities thoughtfully. Colour is used only where it helps you identify beach flags (Activity 2.1) and understand rip currents (Activity 2.2).

## Welcome to your Swim & Water Safety Workbook.

Victoria has some of the most beautiful beaches, rivers, lakes and pools in Australia — and some of the most dangerous conditions. This workbook will help you build the knowledge, skills and confidence to keep yourself and others safe in and around water. Complete all activities thoughtfully and honestly.

# 1 Why Water Safety Matters in Victoria

## Key Knowledge — Victorian Drowning Statistics 2023–24

- 54 fatal drownings in Victoria in 2023–24 — the highest in decades
- 1 in 5 victims were aged 15–24 years old
- Males are 4x more likely to drown than females
- **ALL 54 deaths occurred at unpatrolled locations**
- Inland waterways (rivers, dams) are especially dangerous
- Cold water shock can affect even strong swimmers
- Non-fatal drownings were 60% above the 10-year average
- ~40% of deaths were from CALD backgrounds — highest ever recorded

Source: Life Saving Victoria Drowning Report 2023-24 – [lsv.com.au/research/victorian-drowning-reports/](https://lsv.com.au/research/victorian-drowning-reports/)

## Activity 1.1 — Personal Connection

Individual | ~5 min

Think about your own experiences near or in water. Circle your answer for each question.

| Favourite water environment (circle one):                                                             | My swimming ability (circle one):                                                                          |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Patrolled Beach / Unpatrolled Beach / Public Pool / Private Pool / River / Dam / Lake / I avoid water | Non-swimmer / still learning / Can swim short distances / Comfortable swimmer / Strong / confident swimmer |

## Activity 1.2 — Data Analysis

Individual | ~10 min

Study the Victorian drowning statistics below. Complete the third column with your own interpretation of what each figure tells us.

| Category                | 2023–24 Data                    | What does this tell us?                  |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| Total fatal drownings   | <b>54 deaths</b>                | <i>Write your interpretation here...</i> |
| Young people aged 15–24 | <b>1 in 5 victims</b>           |                                          |
| Gender                  | <b>46 of 54 were male</b>       |                                          |
| Location                | <b>ALL at unpatrolled sites</b> |                                          |

**Question 1.2a [2 marks]**

Using the data above, explain TWO reasons why teenagers and young people in Victoria face a higher risk of drowning.

1. \_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

**Question 1.2b [2 marks]**

All 54 Victorian drowning deaths in 2023–24 occurred at unpatrolled locations. What does this suggest about the importance of swimming at patrolled beaches and pools?

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

## 2 Beach Flags, Signals & Safe Swimming

### Key Knowledge — Australian Beach Flag System

- **Red & Yellow flags** = patrolled swimming area — ALWAYS swim here
- **Single red flag** = dangerous conditions — extreme caution or no entry
- **Black & white quartered** = surfers/watercraft zone — not for swimmers
- **Yellow + black ball** = swimming only — no surfboards allowed
- **Orange windsock** = offshore winds — no inflatables
- **Purple flag** = dangerous marine life present
- Lifeguards are trained professionals — always follow their instructions
- BeachSafe app shows patrolled beaches near you: [beachsafe.org.au](https://beachsafe.org.au)

Source: Surf Life Saving Australia — [sls.com.au](https://sls.com.au) | Life Saving Victoria — [lsv.com.au](https://lsv.com.au)

### Activity 2.1 — Flag Identification ★ COLOUR

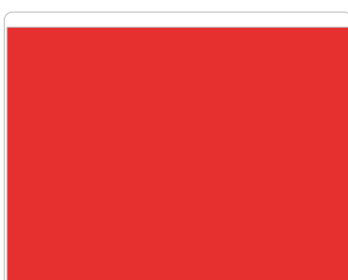
Individual | ~8 min

Below are six beach flag diagrams. Write the correct **name** and **meaning** of each flag in the spaces provided beneath each flag.



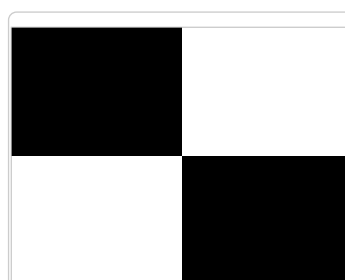
Flag 1: \_\_\_\_\_

Meaning: \_\_\_\_\_



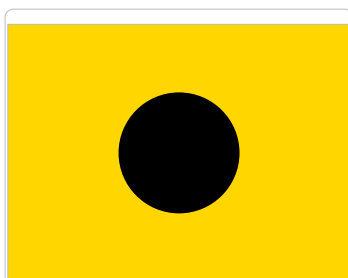
Flag 2: \_\_\_\_\_

Meaning: \_\_\_\_\_



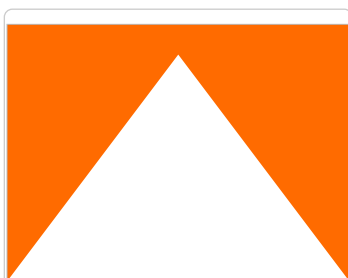
Flag 3: \_\_\_\_\_

Meaning: \_\_\_\_\_



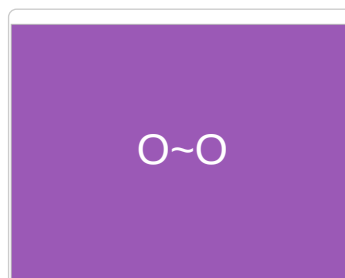
Flag 4: \_\_\_\_\_

Meaning: \_\_\_\_\_



Flag 5: \_\_\_\_\_

Meaning: \_\_\_\_\_



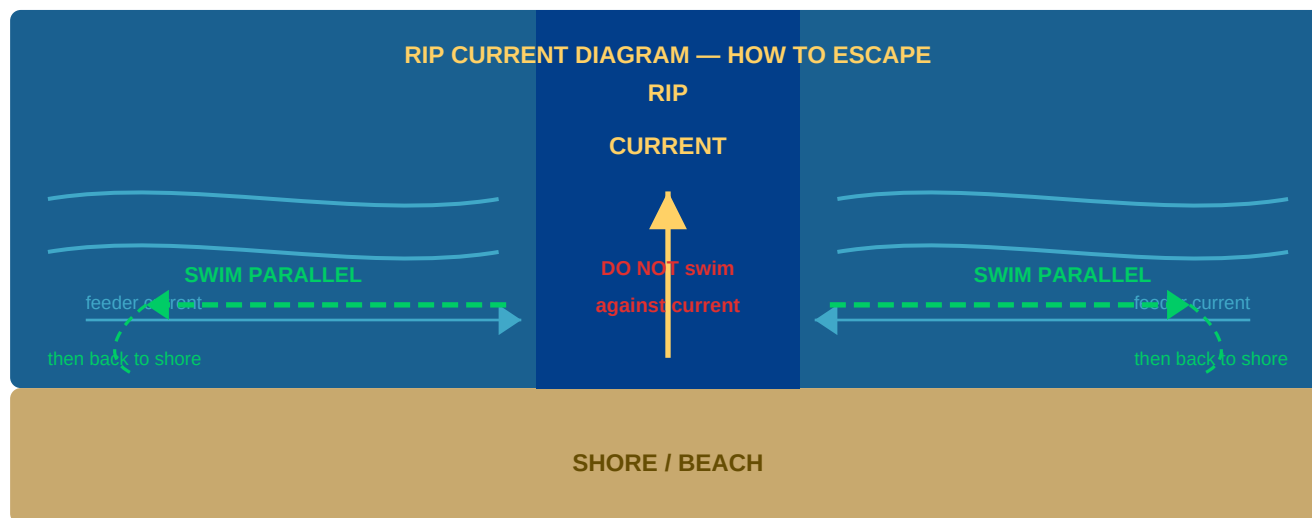
Flag 6: \_\_\_\_\_

Meaning: \_\_\_\_\_

## Activity 2.2 — Rip Currents: How to Escape ★ COLOUR

Individual | ~10 min

Rip currents are one of the leading causes of drowning at Australian beaches. They are fast-moving channels of water that flow from the shore out to sea. Study the diagram carefully, then answer the questions below.



1 Stay CALM

2 FLOAT

3 Swim PARALLEL

4 Angle to shore

5 SIGNAL for help

### Question 2.2a [3 marks]

Using the diagram above, describe in your own words the THREE steps you would take if caught in a rip current.

Step 1: \_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

### Question 2.2b [2 marks]

Why is it dangerous to try to swim directly against a rip current towards shore?

\_\_\_\_\_

### Scenario

**Liam** is a 14-year-old who went to the beach with friends on a hot summer day. They went to an unpatrolled beach. Liam swam out and felt himself being pulled away from shore. He began panicking and tried to sprint-swim directly back to the beach, but was getting more tired. His friends noticed and did not know what to do.

**Question 2.2c [4 marks]**

Identify TWO mistakes Liam and his friends made, and explain what they should have done differently.

*Mistake 1:* \_\_\_\_\_

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### 3 Emergency Response — DRS ABCD

#### Key Knowledge — The DRS ABCD Action Plan

- **Danger** — check for hazards before approaching
- **Response** — check if the person responds to you
- **Send** — call 000 (triple zero) for emergency services
- **Airway** — tilt head back, lift chin, check for obstruction
- **Breathing** — look, listen, feel for up to 10 seconds
- **CPR** — 30 compressions, 2 breaths; repeat until help arrives
- **Defibrillation** — use AED if available; follow voice prompts
- **THROW, DON'T GO** — use reach or throw rescue first

Source: St John Ambulance Victoria — [stjohnvic.com.au/first-aid-resources/](http://stjohnvic.com.au/first-aid-resources/)

#### Critical Safety Rule — THROW, DON'T GO

Most bystanders who enter dangerous water to help end up drowning themselves. Always attempt a reach or throw rescue first. Throw a rope, towel, kickboard, esky lid, or any floating object. Only enter water to rescue if you are trained to do so.

#### Activity 3.1 — DRS ABCD Memory Activity

Individual | ~5 min

Write the word that each letter stands for, then describe what you would DO at each step if you found someone unconscious face-down at the edge of a swimming pool.

| Step | Word   | What I would do:                                                    |
|------|--------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| D    | DANGER | <i>e.g. Look for any electricity, chemicals, or pool hazards...</i> |
| R    |        |                                                                     |
| S    |        |                                                                     |
| A    |        |                                                                     |
| B    |        |                                                                     |
| C    |        |                                                                     |
| D    |        |                                                                     |

#### Activity 3.2 — Rescue Scenario Analysis

Pairs | ~12 min

**Scenario — The River Rope Swing**

**Scene:** It is a hot February day. You and your friends are at a popular (but unpatrolled) rope swing over a river. A 16-year-old you don't know swings out, lets go, and hits the water awkwardly. He sinks and doesn't come back up. His friends are watching from the bank. One of them jumps in to help and also starts struggling. You are standing on the bank. You have a towel, a rope attached to the swing, and your phone.

**Question 3.2a [2 marks]**

What is your **FIRST** action and why? (Consider the "throw, don't go" principle)

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**Question 3.2b [2 marks]**

Why is it dangerous that the friend jumped in? What risk does this create?

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**Question 3.2c [3 marks]**

If you pull the unconscious teenager to the bank and he is not breathing, list the DRS ABCD steps you would take in order.

1. \_\_\_\_\_ 2. \_\_\_\_\_ 3. \_\_\_\_\_

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## 4 Making Safe Decisions Near Water

### Key Knowledge — Factors That Increase Risk

- Peer pressure to swim in dangerous locations
- Overestimating your swimming ability
- Cold water shock (involuntary gasp reflex)
- Alcohol and drug use impairs judgment
- Swimming alone with no-one watching
- Jumping or diving without checking depth
- Ignoring warning signs and flags
- Inflatable toys in open water with offshore winds

### LSV SwimSafe Rules — 5 Rules Before You Enter Water

- **Read Signs** — Always check warning signs, flags, and notices before entering any waterway
- **Enter Feet First** — Never dive or jump into unknown water
- **Stay In Depth** — Only swim where you can comfortably stand, unless you are a confident swimmer
- **Swim With a Friend** — Never swim alone — drowning is silent
- **Signal For Help** — Raise ONE arm if in trouble. Float and conserve energy until help arrives

Source: Life Saving Victoria SwimSafe Program – lsv.com.au

### Activity 4.0 — Hazard Mapping

Pairs | ~10 min

For each Victorian water environment below, list at least THREE specific hazards. Rank each H (High), M (Medium) or L (Low) risk.

| Environment                                | Hazards (list at least 3)           | Risk (H/M/L) | How to stay safe |
|--------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|--------------|------------------|
| Patrolled Beach (e.g. Torquay, Mornington) | 1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____<br>_____ |              |                  |
| River / Dam (e.g. Yarra, Lake Eildon)      | 1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____<br>_____ |              |                  |
| Pool (public, school, or backyard)         | 1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____<br>_____ |              |                  |

#### Question 4.0a [2 marks]

Which environment is MOST dangerous overall, and why? Use Victorian drowning statistics to support your answer.

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**Activity 4.1 — Risk vs. Benefit Analysis**

Individual | ~10 min

For each situation, identify the RISK(S) and a SAFER ALTERNATIVE.

| Situation                                                        | Risk(s) | Safer Alternative |
|------------------------------------------------------------------|---------|-------------------|
| Swimming at an unpatrolled beach at night on a dare from friends |         |                   |
| Using an inflatable lilo in the ocean on a windy day             |         |                   |
| Jumping into a river from rocks without knowing the depth        |         |                   |
| Going for a swim alone in a dam on a hot day                     |         |                   |

**Question 4.1a [3 marks]**

Describe a strategy to resist peer pressure to swim somewhere unsafe. Give a specific example of what you might say to your friends.

Strategy: \_\_\_\_\_

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## 5 Victorian Inland Waterways, Cold Water & Rescue

### Activity 5.1 — Cold Water Shock Research Task

Individual / pair | ~15 min

Victorian rivers, dams and lakes can be dangerously cold even on a hot summer day. Cold water shock is a physiological response that can incapacitate even strong swimmers.

#### Cold Water Shock Facts:

When you suddenly enter cold water (below about 15 degrees C), your body triggers an involuntary gasp reflex, rapid breathing, increased heart rate and blood pressure, and muscle weakness. These responses can cause you to inhale water and drown within minutes, even in shallow water. Alpine lakes such as Lake Eildon are fed by snowmelt and can remain below 15 degrees C even in December and January.

#### Question 5.1a [2 marks]

Describe TWO physical effects cold water has on the body that can increase the risk of drowning.

1. \_\_\_\_\_  
 \_\_\_\_\_  
 \_\_\_\_\_

#### Question 5.1b [2 marks]

What are TWO precautions you should take if you plan to swim or fish at an inland waterway in Victoria?

1. \_\_\_\_\_  
 \_\_\_\_\_  
 \_\_\_\_\_

#### Question 5.1c — Research [2 marks]

Visit one of the sites below and find ONE fact about Victorian inland waterway safety you did not know before. Write the exact URL of the page you found it on.

Fact: \_\_\_\_\_  
 \_\_\_\_\_  
 \_\_\_\_\_

[vic.gov.au/water-safety](http://vic.gov.au/water-safety) | [lsv.com.au](http://lsv.com.au) | [paddle.org.au](http://paddle.org.au) | [park.vic.gov.au](http://park.vic.gov.au)

### Activity 5.2 — Throw Rescue: Rank Your Equipment

Groups of 3-4 | ~8 min

Based on guidelines from the **Royal Life Saving Society Australia (RLSSA)**, the safest rescues keep YOU out of the water. Rank the items from BEST (1) to WORST (5) and explain WHY.

| Item                            | Rank (1-5) | Why? (advantage or limitation) |
|---------------------------------|------------|--------------------------------|
| Coiled rope / throw bag         |            |                                |
| Life ring attached to the jetty |            |                                |

| Item                                          | Rank (1-5) | Why? (advantage or limitation) |
|-----------------------------------------------|------------|--------------------------------|
| Jumping in and swimming to them               |            |                                |
| Throwing a pool noodle or esky lid            |            |                                |
| Holding out a towel or clothing from the bank |            |                                |

Source: RLSSA rescue guidelines – royallifesaving.com.au

### Activity 5.3 — Alcohol, Risk & Water

Individual | ~8 min

Alcohol is a significant factor in Victorian drowning deaths.

#### Question 5.3a [3 marks]

List THREE specific ways that alcohol affects the body that increase the risk of drowning.

1. \_\_\_\_\_
- \_\_\_\_\_
- \_\_\_\_\_

#### Question 5.3b [2 marks]

A group of older teenagers are at a pool party. Some have been drinking. One decides to swim "to cool off." What are TWO specific risk factors that make this more dangerous than swimming sober?

1. \_\_\_\_\_
- \_\_\_\_\_

## 6 Personal Action Plan & Communication Campaign

### Activity 6.1 — Personal Water Safety Action Plan

Individual | ~12 min

#### 6.1a — My Swimming Goals

What is one swimming or water safety skill you want to improve this year?

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#### 6.1b — My SwimSafe Commitment

Write the FIVE LSV SwimSafe rules. Circle the one most important for you personally. Explain why below.

Rule 1: \_\_\_\_\_ Rule 2: \_\_\_\_\_ Rule 3: \_\_\_\_\_

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Most important for me because:

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#### 6.1c — My Safety Action Plan

Circle the scenario most relevant to you:

Beach day at Torquay / Mornington Peninsula | River or lake trip (e.g. Yarra, Eildon) | Pool party at a friend's house | Kayaking / paddling trip (paddle.org.au)

| Plan Element                             | My Plan: |
|------------------------------------------|----------|
| Hazards I might face                     |          |
| Safety strategies I'll use               |          |
| Emergency plan (if something goes wrong) |          |
| Equipment I'll bring                     |          |
| Who I'll go with (buddy rule!)           |          |

### Activity 6.2 — Communication Campaign (Assessment Task)

Individual | ~25 min | Summative

Create a short water safety communication product for a specific audience. Choose ONE option:

#### All options must include:

At least ONE accurate statistic with its source URL | A clear safety message | A call to action

| Option                                  | Task Description                                                                                                                                       |
|-----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| A — Social media post                   | Design 1-2 Instagram/TikTok slides for 13-17 year olds. Include a statistic, a visual element (drawn or described), and a call to action.              |
| B — Letter to Year 5 student            | Write a 200-word letter explaining THREE things they must know about Victorian water safety before summer.                                             |
| C — Multilingual fact sheet (Extension) | Design a simple fact sheet explaining beach flags and Victorian waterway dangers for someone new to Australia. At least 5 key points and 2 statistics. |

**Plan your campaign:***Option chosen:* \_\_\_\_\_*Target audience:* \_\_\_\_\_*Statistic I will use:* \_\_\_\_\_*Source URL:* \_\_\_\_\_*Key message:* \_\_\_\_\_*Call to action:* \_\_\_\_\_**Draft your campaign here (or attach a separate page):**

## Self-Assessment

Rate your confidence in each area. Circle: **Not yet confident** / **Getting there** / **Confident**

| Skill / Knowledge Area                          | Not yet confident     | Getting there         | Confident             |
|-------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|
| Identifying beach flags and their meanings      | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> |
| Knowing what to do if caught in a rip current   | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> |
| Following DRS ABCD in an emergency              | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> |
| Recalling all 5 LSV SwimSafe rules              | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> |
| Making safe decisions near water                | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> |
| Understanding Victorian drowning statistics     | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> |
| Identifying hazards at different waterway types | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> |
| Explaining the Throw, Don't Go rescue principle | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> |

**One thing I want to learn more about:**

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Life Saving Victoria: [lsv.com.au](http://lsv.com.au) | Drowning Reports: [lsv.com.au/research/victorian-drowning-reports/](http://lsv.com.au/research/victorian-drowning-reports/) | RLSSA: [royallifesaving.com.au](http://royallifesaving.com.au) | BeachSafe: [beachsafe.org.au](http://beachsafe.org.au) | Paddle Australia: [paddle.org.au](http://paddle.org.au) | Parks Victoria: [park.vic.gov.au](http://park.vic.gov.au) | Victorian Curriculum: [victoriancurriculum.vcaa.vic.edu.au](http://victoriancurriculum.vcaa.vic.edu.au)